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CENTERPIECE

Fire marshals continue to investigate fire that killed six people

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Officials investigate the scene of the Aug. 10 fatal fire in Waldorf.

Maryland State Fire Marshal's Office

A day after a  Waldorf house fire killed six people, neighbors consoled a crying woman who sat in front of the destroyed home.

Tucked between houses in Constitution Hills, a street was blocked off Monday by yellow police tape with patrol cars sitting guard. People went between comforting the woman and taking in the scene of the blaze that killed four children and two adults on Sunday, Aug. 10.

While part of the house still stands, the foundations on the right side were burned. Jagged pieces of wood jutted from a large hole above the garage.

The enclosed porch, where investigators determined the fire originated, was hardly recognizable.

First responders on Monday continued work on getting items out of the house and cleaning the area. A deputy from the Maryland State Fire Marshal's Office said they were unable to release the names of the victims until they received confirmation from the Office of Chief Medical Examiner, which could take days or even a week.

"This is an unimaginable loss for the community," Acting State Fire Marshal Jason M. Mowbray said in a press release Sunday. "Our hearts go out to the families impacted by this heartbreaking event."

At around 8:40 a.m. Sunday, the Waldorf Volunteer Fire Department responded to the fire in the 3000 block of North Declaration Court.

Around 3 p.m., the Maryland State Fire Marshal confirmed three people in the Waldorf home were killed, according to the agency's social media site. A few hours later the fire marshal's office updated the death toll to six.

"Preliminary information indicates the victims are believed to be the wife and three children of the homeowner, along with the wife and child of another surviving occupant of the home," according to the fire marshal's office.

Although names have not been released, three of the children attended Daniel of St. Thomas Jenifer Elementary School, Charles County Board of Education Chair Yonelle Moore Lee said at the Tuesday board meeting.

A woman passing the house on North Declaration Court Sunday morning noticed the fire on the side of the house and notified the homeowner, said Oliver Alkire, master deputy state fire marshal.

Once she knocked on the door, one man immediately left the house and another man followed, he said.

A Charles County sheriff's deputy was the first to arrive and was told six others were inside, according to a release from the state fire marshal sent Monday. Deputies attempted to enter the house but could not due to the heavy smoke and flames.

Another adult arrived at the home while the fire department was on the scene, the release said. Investigators were assisted by K9 "Taylor," the Calvert K-9 Search Team and the Charles County Collapse Team.

An American Red Cross emergency vehicle and response team was at the scene of the fire Sunday and provided immediate assistance and mental health support, according to an email statement from the Red Cross sent to Southern Maryland News.

Trained Red Cross disaster workers continue to work with the family to provide financial assistance, recovery resources and mental health and condolence care, the email said.

Investigators remained on the scene Sunday evening investigating the cause of the fire.

“No evidence has been recovered of a criminal act; and we continue to examine all accidental causes. This will remain an active scene until the late evening hours,” according to the fire marshal’s office.

As part of every origin and cause investigation, fire investigators work to determine whether smoke alarms were activated during the incident. This can be “challenging because intense heat, heavy smoke and the water used in the firefighting operations often damage or destroy critical alarm components,” according to the fire marshal’s office.

While all of the smoke alarms within the first and second floors of the home were destroyed, investigators did locate a smoke alarm in the basement; however, it was disconnected and had no battery installed, according to the fire marshal’s office.

Even if an alarm did sound, occupants or first responders may not have heard it due to closed doors, distance from the device, background noise or the fire spreading rapidly and overpowering the sound.

“We must methodically examine every possible fire cause and contributing factor,” Mowbray said in the Monday release. “Determining whether smoke alarms were sounding is not always straightforward, but it is essential to understanding how and why tragedies like this occur.”

Deputy fire marshals continued through the week working alongside Charles sheriff’s officers at the scene.
